OREGON

The Beaver State



Oregon's timber country has never been a place that had much patience for fussiness. In the mill towns that stretched along the Willamette Valley and into the dense Douglas fir forests of the Coast Range, meals were built for men who worked with their hands and came to the table genuinely hungry. It was in this culture—sawdust-scented, hardworking, and unapologetically practical—that Jo Jo potatoes found their home.

The potato itself arrived in the Pacific Northwest through a long chain of hands. The Hudson's Bay Company brought cultivated potatoes to Fort Vancouver in the 1820s, planting them at trading posts to sustain their crews through the long, rain-soaked winters. It expanded on this, encouraging potato cultivation at Fort Vancouver along the Columbia River, where Chief Factor John McLoughlin oversaw what became one of the most productive agricultural operations in the early Northwest. By the mid-1800s, Oregon's wet, volcanic soil had proven so hospitable to the crop that potatoes were feeding settlers, traders, and native communities alike up and down the valley.

When the timber industry exploded in western Oregon in the late 19th century, mill towns like Roseburg, Eugene, and Cottage Grove filled with loggers, millworkers, and their families—people who needed food that was fast, filling, and built to satisfy a body that had spent ten hours swinging an axe or feeding lumber through a screaming saw blade. Taverns and cookhouses became the social centers of these communities, and their menus reflected the crowd they served. Potatoes were cheap, abundant, and endlessly adaptable. Someone—no single cook has ever been credited, and perhaps that is fitting for a dish so democratic—discovered that cutting them into thick wedges, seasoning them boldly with garlic, paprika, and pepper, and frying them until the outside shattered and the inside went soft and steaming, produced something that was almost impossible to stop eating.

The name Jo Jo itself remains pleasantly mysterious. Some food historians suggest it was simply the kind of cheerful, doubled nickname that American diners and tavern owners loved to give their most popular items—approachable, memorable, impossible to say without a little warmth. Whatever its origin, the name stuck, and by the mid-20th century Jo Jo potatoes had spread from the cookhouses of the Coast Range to diners, bowling alleys, taverns, and family kitchens across Oregon and the broader Pacific Northwest, always served hot, always generous, and always exactly what you needed.

What makes them worth making today is what made them worth eating then—that extraordinary contrast between the crackling, spice-crusted exterior and the tender, yielding potato within. They are the kind of thing that disappears from the platter before the meal is even properly underway, and the kind of thing your guests will quietly hope you make again. Pull out your largest baking sheet, don't be shy with the seasoning, and give them the heat they deserve. Oregon's timber workers knew what they were doing.

JO JO POTATOES

Crispy outside, tender inside, these thick-cut potato wedges bridge the gap between French fries and home fries.

Yield: 4–6 servings

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large russet potatoes, scrubbed (skin on)
- 1 cup all-purpose flour
- 2 tsp salt
- 1 tsp black pepper
- 1 tsp paprika
- ½ tsp garlic powder
- ½ tsp onion powder
- ½ tsp cayenne pepper (optional, for heat)
- 1 cup buttermilk (or milk + 1 Tbsp lemon juice)
- Vegetable or peanut oil, for frying
- For dipping (optional): Ranch dressing, fry sauce, or ketchup.

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Prep the potatoes*: Scrub and rinse potatoes well. Cut each potato lengthwise into 6–8 thick wedges. Place in a pot, cover with cold water, and parboil for 5 minutes. Drain and let cool slightly.
2. *Heat oil*: Heat oil in a deep fryer or heavy cast-iron pot to 350°F (175°C).
3. *Season and dredge*: In one bowl, pour the buttermilk. In another bowl, combine flour, salt, pepper, paprika, garlic powder, onion powder, and cayenne. Dip each wedge in buttermilk, then dredge in the seasoned flour mixture until well coated.
4. *Fry*: Fry in batches (don't overcrowd) for 4–6 minutes, turning occasionally, until golden brown and crisp. Transfer to a wire rack or paper towel-lined tray to drain.
5. *Serve*: Sprinkle with a pinch of salt while still hot and serve with your favorite dipping sauce.

